

FOUR SIGNS THE WOUND HASN'T SURFACED YET

Lesson 3 · Resource 3 of 3

Resource 2 gave you four stages and one lock: deduce the territory, visualize the scene, press it with Socratic questioning, then confirm it with a sentence that holds without argument. Most sessions don't fail because a writer skipped a stage. They fail because a stage got rushed, and something that only *looks* like the output of that stage gets carried forward into the next one.

This is a field guide for catching that in the moment — one sign for each stage, in the order you'll actually run into them.

Sign 1 — Stuck at Category

Shows up after Stage 1 (Deductive Reasoning)

Deduction is supposed to narrow the territory, not name the wound. If what you're holding after Stage 1 still sounds like "a difficult childhood," "early abandonment," or "growing up poor," you're at a category — the kind of description that could belong to any number of different characters and produce any number of different beliefs. That's expected output for Stage 1. It's a problem only if it's still what you're working with once Stage 2 should have supplied something specific.

Worked failure: A writer names the wound as "a neglectful home." Pressed for the scene, they still have only the category — no age, no room, no single moment. The territory was correctly identified. The scene was never found. Return to Stage 2 and let an image arrive rather than refining the label.

Sign 2 — Emotion Instead of Scene

Shows up after Stage 2 (Intuitive Visualization)

The image that surfaces in Stage 2 sometimes arrives already translated into a feeling — "he felt like he never mattered" — before the scene underneath it has been named. A feeling is a conclusion, not a wound. A camera couldn't film "he felt like he never mattered." It could film the thing that produced the feeling.

Worked failure: "*She felt invisible growing up.*" Pressed further: "*She was the third of four kids. The other three were the athlete, the musician, and the baby. Nobody asked her a single direct question the whole summer she turned eleven.*" The second version is the wound. The first was the emotion standing in front of it.

Sign 3 — The Connection Requires Argument

Shows up during Stage 3 (Socratic Pressure)

This is the test Resource 1 opened with and Resource 2 built the whole method around: does the wound explain the belief immediately, or do you have to walk someone through the reasoning? If your coach needs a chain of logic to accept that this scene produces this belief, Stage 3 isn't finished — you're still one layer above the real wound, holding something plausible instead of something inevitable.

Worked failure: A writer connects a childhood move to an adult belief that "nothing lasts." The coach asks why that specific move, and not any of the character's other experiences, produced that specific conclusion. The writer has to explain — several sentences of reasoning — before the connection makes sense. That gap is the signal. Keep pressing.

Sign 4 — Satisfying Instead of Surprising

Shows up at Stage 4 (Origin Statement and Chain Confirmation)

A wound can pass Signs 1 through 3 and still not be the real one. This last sign is about the *feeling* of the lock, not its logic. When the wound-to-belief sentence completes cleanly, you'll feel one of two things: satisfaction — "good, that works, the structure holds" — or recognition — "of course, that's exactly it." Only the second one means you're done. Satisfaction is what invention feels like. Recognition is what discovery feels like.

Worked failure: A writer's lock reads correctly on paper — every clause connects — but when they say it aloud, the response is a shrug, not a jolt. That's the tell. The wound that produces recognition rather than satisfaction is usually one degree more specific and one degree less expected than the one the writer first proposed.

What it looks like when none of these signs are present is the manager story from the Lesson 3 video: a single sentence, spoken once, on a drive home, at age eleven. Not a theme. Not an emotion. Not an argument you have to build. A scene — and the belief it produced needs no defending.

That's the full sequence: territory, scene, pressure, lock. When your wound clears all four signs, the causal chain from Resource 2 is complete — wound, hidden truth, anchor behavior, three layers, none of them requiring the others to be explained.

What comes next: the wound produced a belief that was a rational conclusion, given what your character lived through. Lesson 4 picks up where this one ends — tracing what happens when that rational conclusion hardens into something less accurate: not "this is how the world works," but "this is who I permanently am." That distortion is The Lie, and it's the most consequential step in the excavation still ahead of you.